

Notre Dame - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | INDEPENDENT

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	National-title caliber; top-five baseline with unusually strong continuity
Preseason consensus	AP No. 4 (1,510 points; six first-place votes) · SP+ No. 3
Returning production	72% (No. 1) overall · Off. 67% (No. 18) · Def. 77% (No. 2)
Primer power rating	+26.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.8 wins · most likely 11-1
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar elite level, with different composition
Confidence	High

2026 identity: Notre Dame pairs returning QB CJ Carr and OC Mike Denbrock's explosive offense with a deep DC Chris Ash defense. The challenge is replacing two first-round RBs and several veteran front pieces without losing 2025's elite efficiency.

Bottom line: Notre Dame has the quarterback stability, returning core and schedule of a national-title contender. The downside is concentrated at RB, interior OL/front and unsettled specialist or availability spots.

Beats expectations if: RB Aneyas Williams keeps the run game explosive, the C/RG alignment settles quickly, and the front replaces DT Gabriel Rubio, EDGE Jordan Botelho, DT Donovan Hinish and DT Jared Dawson without losing disruption.

Disappoints if: The post-RB Jeremiyah Love/RB Jadarian Price backfield loses explosiveness, injuries thin the OL/front, and specialist turnover costs field position in the few close games.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB CJ Carr is the established returning QB1, removing the biggest preseason uncertainty that usually limits elite-team confidence.
- 2 National baseline:** Notre Dame is No. 3 in SP+, No. 4 in the AP poll, and No. 1 in returning production overall.
- 3 First-round RB losses:** Both 2025 lead backs, RB Jeremiyah Love and RB Jadarian Price, were first-round NFL draft departures.
- 4 ★ CB Leonard Moore:** CB Leonard Moore anchors a loaded secondary and carries the roster's strongest national-recognition profile.
- 5 Play-caller:** OC Mike Denbrock is the confirmed 2026 primary offensive game-day play-caller.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	10-2 (0-0 Independent)	● Excellent
Scoring	42.0 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	458.5 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	203.4 YPG · 5.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	9.48 YPA · 25 TD / 6 INT	● Elite
Third downs	48.1%	● Elite
Scoring defense	17.6 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	313.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	100.1 YPG · 3.0 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	213.4 YPG · 6.20 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Elite

Notre Dame's 10-2 profile was genuinely balanced: elite scoring, passing efficiency and third-down offense paired with elite scoring and run defense. There was no obvious conventional-stat weakness entering 2026.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+11.99 · No. 3	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.272 · No. 3	● Elite
Off. success rate	47.6% · No. 22	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	17.8% · No. 2	● Elite
Havoc allowed	13.0% · No. 31	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+11.41 · No. 5	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.167 · No. 10	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	35.6% · No. 12	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.9% · No. 24	● Very good
Havoc created	18.7% · No. 13	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Notre Dame was championship-caliber on both sides, pairing top-three offensive EPA with elite explosiveness and top-13 havoc creation. The 2026 risk is replacement and availability, not a fragile 2025 baseline.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Marcus Freeman - returning	● ↔ High-end program continuity after a 10-2 season.
OC/TE	Mike Denbrock - returning	● ↔ System continuity is a major positive, with Denbrock confirmed as the primary offensive game-day play-caller.
DC	Chris Ash - returning	● ↔ Returns after a top-five opponent-adjusted defense.
Co-DC/DB	◆ Aaron Henry - new	● ↔ Adds experienced secondary support without signaling a wholesale scheme break.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Mylan Graham	Ohio State	● ↔ Top-four WR candidate who helps replace receiver turnover.
♦ WR Quincy Porter	Ohio State	● ↔ Material WR addition, but a minor Aug. 21 procedure leaves him a couple of weeks from returning.

Out	To	Loss
RB Jeremiah Love	NFL (Arizona), Round 1, No. 3	● ↓ First-round lead-back loss.
RB Jadarian Price	NFL (Seattle), Round 1, No. 32	● ↓ Second first-round RB loss removes proven explosiveness.
WR Malachi Fields	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 3, No. 74	● ↓ Material receiver departure.
OL Billy Schrauth	NFL (Tampa Bay), Round 5, No. 160	● ↓ Meaningful OL departure increases interior-line replacement pressure.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Slightly worse composition, but still high-end.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ EDGE Keon Keeley	Alabama	● ↑ Top-four edge addition with high-end upside.
♦ CB DJ McKinney	Colorado	● ↑ Projected starting field corner in a strong secondary.
♦ DT Francis Brewu	Pittsburgh	● ↔ Material DT rotation addition.

Out	To	Loss
DT Gabriel Rubio	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 6, No. 210	● ↓ Material interior-line loss.
EDGE Jordan Botelho	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Experienced edge departure.
DT Donovan Hinish	football retirement	● ↓ Captain and meaningful interior contributor leaves.
DT Jared Dawson	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ Seven-start interior-DL experience departs.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Similar high-end unit with significant front turnover.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Explosive, efficient balanced attack within a returning offensive structure.	QB Carr continuity, explosive-play creation and stable high-end OL pieces.	Replacing two first-round RBs while settling C/RG and WR availability.
Defense	Deep rotation-heavy front seven paired with a nationally decorated secondary.	Strong success-rate/EPA defense, experienced linebackers and elite coverage talent.	Interior-front turnover and camp-health questions.
Special teams	Promising new kicker with unsettled punter/return structure.	K Porath has the strongest placekicker information.	Punter/return assignments and coverage continuity.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A–	● ↔	High	QB CJ Carr is the established returning starter in an elite offense.
RB	● B+	● ↓	Medium	Replacing two first-round RBs lowers continuity despite RB Aneyas Williams' upside.
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	A reloaded group remains talented, but Quincy Porter is still a couple of weeks from returning after a minor procedure.
TE	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	A solid room remains, but the proven role profile is lighter than 2025.
OL	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	High-end anchors remain, but the C/RG alignment is still unsettled.
DL/Edge	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	Depth and EDGE Boubacar Traore sustain upside despite significant front turnover.
LB	● A	● ↔	High	LB Drayk Bowen and LB Kyngstonn Viliamu-Asa anchor an elite returning group.
Secondary	● A	● ↔	High	CB Leonard Moore anchors a nationally decorated secondary.
Special teams	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	K Spencer Porath leads a reset specialist group; punter and return roles remain open.
Coaching	● A–	● ↔	High	HC Marcus Freeman, OC/play-caller Mike Denbrock and DC Chris Ash provide strong continuity.
Overall	● A+	● ↔	High	Top-five quality with elite continuity and replacement risk concentrated at RB and in the front.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
CJ Carr	QB	● National award-caliber returning starter	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Established QB1 in an elite underlying offense.
★ Leonard Moore	CB	● National star / All-America candidate	AP first team · Walter Camp first team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Thorpe · Walter Camp POY	Premier anchor of a championship-caliber secondary.
Boubacar Traore	EDGE	● High-end national edge	Bednarik	Top returning edge reference amid front turnover.
Anthonie Knapp	OL	● All-America caliber lineman	Walter Camp first team · Outland	Stable OL anchor while C/RG remains unsettled.
Aneyas Williams	RB	● High-upside first-year lead back	-	Inherits the clearest vacancy after both 2025 lead backs became first-round picks.
Drayk Bowen	LB	● High-end national linebacker	Nagurski · Butkus	Experienced centerpiece of a deep linebacker room.
Kyngstonn Viliamu-Asa	LB	● All-America caliber linebacker	AP second team · Walter Camp second team · Butkus	Pairs with Bowen in an elite second-level rotation; probable status still merits monitoring.
Spencer Porath	K	● High-upside specialist	Lou Groza	Leading kicker information in an operation replacing both 2025 primary specialists.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable for a title contender; not the primary reason to downgrade the roster.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 62
Hardest stretch	at BYU → Navy (neutral) → Miami → Boston College → SMU, with the bye before Navy
Swing games	Miami, at BYU
Advantage	Miami and SMU are at home, and the late schedule contains few true road tests.
Expected	10.8 wins · most likely 11-1
Floor / ceiling	9-3 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Expect Notre Dame to be priced as an elite team; value depends more on whether markets misprice RB/front turnover than on finding them broadly underrated.
Back them when	Against opponents that cannot force obvious passing downs or stress the reconfigured interior OL, especially once the new RB rotation proves it can preserve early-down explosiveness.
Fade/pass when	At premium numbers against elite defensive fronts before the new backfield/interior OL proves itself, or if material camp-health questions persist.
Key monitor	RB workload/efficiency, C/RG alignment, Quincy Porter return timing, DT rotation/health, punter/return roles, offensive caller if clarified
Week 1 baseline	Notre Dame -22.5 vs. Wisconsin (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Notre Dame primer +26.5 minus Wisconsin primer +4.0; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Notre Dame -20.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Notre Dame enters 2026 with top-five quality, the nation's No. 1 returning-production profile and an established QB in CJ Carr. The roster remains elite even after major NFL losses at RB and along the defensive front.

The title case is straightforward: preserve early-down explosiveness, settle the interior OL and specialist roles, and let a deep defense carry its usual efficiency. With a moderate schedule, 11-1 is the most likely outcome.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [fall camp](#) · [QB CJ Carr](#) · [NFL draft exits](#) · [camp injuries](#) · [OC Mike Denbrock](#) · [Porter availability update](#)

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